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Windsor suspends license plate readers amid privacy concerns

Windsor pauses license plate readers

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The Flock cameras, which scan license plates of every passing vehicle, were installed at busy intersections and roads throughout Windsor to help police investigate crimes.

Windsor resident Jeff Pitkin said he supports the decision to shut down the cameras.

"I'm glad they got rid of it," he said. "I don't know how it's being used. That's what it is so I'd rather stay safe and secure rather than have my information out just because I'm driving around they can tell where I'm at at whatever time."

Several residents spoke against the cameras at the town council meeting, expressing concerns about data storage.

"While our police department has policies in place to ensure our officers handle the information collected correctly, we have no power over others who have access to that data," one resident said.

"We know there are bad actors in the federal government for targeting people because of their race and because of their gender identity and because of the religion and political affiliation ideas," said another person.

Windsor Police Chief Donald Melanson said officers view the suspension as limiting their investigative capabilities.

"They would take that as something that inhibits their job. They are the ones that have to deal with the victims of crime and that's very difficult to do. They're the ones that are going to have to tell people we don't have this tool available to follow that lead," he said.

Flock Safety said it has no relationship with ICE and that data remains secure and under Windsor's control.

"We are working closely with the City of Windsor to address their concerns and ensure they are familiar with all of the data sharing controls and audit tools built into our system," said the company after the vote.

Retired Lt. Paul Vance said the cameras can be useful for police, but data control is crucial.

“The control of that data, though, is extremely important from a law enforcement perspective and from a civilian perspective, people don’t want their data out there. They want to control and they want to make sure that the controls are very, very secure,” he said.

Windsor’s mayor said the suspension is temporary while the town works to revise contract language with Flock to better protect resident data. If the contract is terminated early, the town will pay around \$8,000.

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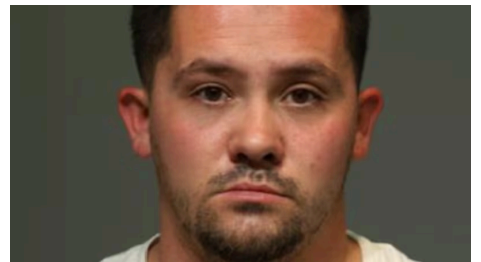
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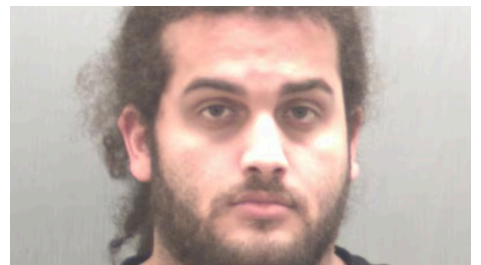
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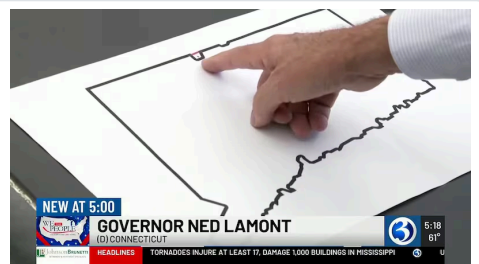
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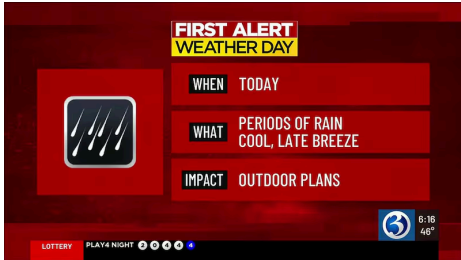


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